



BEFORE

The anticommunist foreign policy of the United States clashed with Vietnamese nationalists who wished to unite their country under communist rule.

LIBERTY LOANS

The American public's support for its armed services dates back to World War I, when people bought billions of dollars of Liberty Loans to finance the war effort. There was

similar mass support for American troops during World War II and the Cold War << 406–07, of which Vietnam was part.



US POSTER FOR LIBERTY LOANS

TRUMAN'S POLICY

The US had fought alongside the communist USSR in World War II << 392–405, but relations between the two broke down as the Cold War began. In 1947, faced with a possible communist threat to Greece and Turkey, President Truman pledged “American support for free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures.” Known as the Truman Doctrine, this guided US foreign policy throughout the Vietnam War.

COLONIAL VIETNAM

In 1941 Ho Chi Minh, a Vietnamese nationalist and communist, created the Viet Minh to fight Japanese occupation. He declared the country independent after Japan's defeat in World War II in 1945 << 402–03. When the French resumed their colonial control << 412–13, a bitter war began that ended in French defeat in 1954. The Geneva Accords of 1954 divided Vietnam temporarily into a communist north and a pro-American south.



The Vietnam War

The Vietnam War was the longest and bloodiest of the many conflicts of the Cold War. The American army was technologically superior, but was defeated by the far more effective tactics of the Vietnamese nationalist and communist army wishing to unite their country and free it from foreign control.

The division of Vietnam in 1954 (see BEFORE) did not bring peace to the country. The US wished to prevent the spread of communism throughout Southeast Asia, believing that one country after another would fall to communist regimes (the so-called “domino effect”) and was prepared to use military action to prevent this. The Geneva Accords had stipulated that joint elections should take place in 1956 to decide the future of a reunified

Vietnam—these elections never took place. In 1955, US president Dwight D. Eisenhower helped the anticommunist Ngo Dinh Diem to take power in a corrupt election in the south, and sent hundreds of military advisors to support the new government.

North Vietnam did not accept the partition of their country and launched attacks on South Vietnam. Anti-Diem South Vietnamese—labeled Viet Cong (“Vietnamese Communist”) by Diem,

although many were nationalists—took up arms to fight Diem's government, led by the National Liberation Front, an alliance of political groups based in North Vietnam.

Eisenhower's support for South Vietnam increased under his successor, John F. Kennedy. By the end of 1963, South Vietnam had received \$500 million in US aid. In August 1964 the USS *Maddox* was conducting electronic surveillance of the North Vietnamese



coast in the Gulf of Tonkin. The ship was fired on by two torpedo boats challenging its presence in North Vietnamese waters. It fired back, sinking one boat. On August 7, the US Congress passed a resolution approving retaliatory raids against North Vietnamese naval bases and